

Compound Nouns

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

A compound noun combines words into one idea. Key rules:

- 1** The first noun is like an adjective and stays singular — a car park, a toothbrush.
- 2** Only the last word is made plural — bus stops, swimming pools.
- 3** Written as one word, two words, or hyphenated — depends on the item.

Numbers + noun before another noun are singular and hyphenated: a ten-year-old boy, a two-hour film.

At a glance

Compound	Note	Plural
bus stop	two words	bus stops
toothbrush	one word	toothbrush es
shoe shop	first noun singular	shoe shops
mother-in-law	hyphenated	mothers-in-law
ten-year-old	number + noun (singular)	ten-year- olds

Learning objectives

- Can form compound nouns keeping the first noun singular (CEFR B1).
- Can pluralise only the final element.
- Can use hyphenated number + noun modifiers (a two-hour delay).

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Compound Nouns · CEFR B1

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. I bought new shoes at the ____ .

- A. shoe shop
- B. shoes shop
- C. shoe's shop
- D. shoes' shop

2. There are three ____ on this street.

- A. bus stops
- B. buses stops
- C. bus stop
- D. bus stopes

3. It's only a ____ walk from here.

- A. five-minute
- B. five-minutes
- C. five minute's
- D. fives-minute

4. Both my ____ came to the wedding.

- A. mothers-in-law
- B. mother-in-laws
- C. mothers-in-laws
- D. mother-in-law's

5. Can you pass me a ____ ?

- A. coffee cup
- B. coffees cup
- C. coffee's cup
- D. cup coffee

6. We stayed in a hotel with two ____ .

- A. swimming pools
- B. swimmings pool
- C. swimming pool
- D. swimming pooles

7. She's a ____ girl.

- A. ten-year-old
- B. ten-years-old
- C. ten year olds
- D. ten-year's-old

8. Put your dirty clothes in the ____ .

- A. washing machine
- B. washings machine
- C. washing's machine
- D. machine washing

9. Correct this: 'It's a three-days trip.'

- A. It's a three-day trip.
- B. It's a three days trip.
- C. It's a three-day's trip.
- D. The sentence is already correct.

10. In a compound noun, which part is normally made plural?

- A. Only the last word.
- B. Only the first word.
- C. Both words.
- D. Neither word.

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. shoe shop** — The first noun stays singular: 'shoe shop'.
2. **A. bus stops** — Only the last word takes the plural: 'bus stops'.
3. **A. five-minute** — A number + noun before a noun is singular: 'a five-minute walk'.
4. **A. mothers-in-law** — The main noun 'mother' takes the plural: 'mothers-in-law'.
5. **A. coffee cup** — First noun singular: 'coffee cup'.
6. **A. swimming pools** — Only the last word is plural: 'swimming pools'.
7. **A. ten-year-old** — Singular, hyphenated before the noun: 'a ten-year-old girl'.
8. **A. washing machine** — Compound noun, first part singular: 'washing machine'.
9. **A. It's a three-day trip.** — Number + noun before a noun is singular: 'a three-day trip'.
10. **A. Only the last word.** — Only the final element takes the plural (bus stops).